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'SAFETY GEAR IS NOW THE MAJOR GROSSER'

Sydenhams Road, dubbed "the Blue Collar Uniform Hub of Chennai", supports a section of the unorganised sector that only continues to thrive and grow bigger due to a variety of intrinsic factors **P3**



THE NUTS AND BOLTS OF CREATIVITY

Sculptor G. Sooriyamoorthy promotes the idea of "art made difficult"; and there is a method to this madness. His works will be on display at Lalit Kala Akademi from October 10 to 15 **P4**



▼ The dog being 'treated' at SILAI factory; (below) the lady with the dog and after it went missing. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND GAYATRI NAIR

Besant Nagar's golden dog 'safe and glowing still'

Recently, the dog made up of industrial fibre went missing causing widespread consternation

PRINCE FREDERICK

A street dog regularly seen on Besant Avenue Road in Besant Nagar went missing last week, sparking a discussion that found resonance beyond the neighbourhood. Those regularly driving through Besant Avenue Road had also noticed the canine's absence. One of them was Rudra, a girl studying in a school nearby. And notably, this girl is a member of what is called Thiruvannamiyur Changemakers Club, a children's collective that seeks to address civic issues in the neighbourhood their parents and older relatives have given up as lost causes.

"This incident was brought to light by Rudra, a young Thiruvannamiyur Changemaker who studies at Adyar Theosophical Academy and

she sees this dog on her daily commute. She is just nine years old," Gayatri Nair points out. Now, as luck would have it, Gayatri, also a resident of Thiruvannamiyur, happens to be a photographer and key member of Chennai Photo Biennale, and believes in taking problems head-on, particularly those of the civic category. On being informed about the missing dog, Gayatri clicked images of the woman robbed of her pet, and spread the word.

Anyone who has not seen this dog might dismiss this as brouhaha. But this was no ordinary four-legged creature: it glowed gold and was always in the company of this lady, equally gold-spangled.

The lady is a permanent resident of what is called "selfie point" on Besant Avenue Road, frequented by those who believe in walking

their illnesses away, a belief partially strengthened by a Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) initiative.

GCC had designed a Health Walk Route in Besant Nagar with much of the walking taking place on Besant Avenue Road under the shade cast by the trees on the Theosophical Society peeping out curiously. And a halting point where people, the walking crowd, could rest and click a few selfies was created; hence the name "selfie point". And this lady, a fitness freak always accompanied by an equally spry dog, now missing, had been signed on as brand ambassador for the Health Walk, and stationed at this selfie point. Two others recruited for the same role as brand ambassador are men, also gold-coloured from head to toe.

SILAI, a sculpture brand had "recruited" this team of fitness-fo-



cussed brand ambassadors for Health Walk. All the three humans and the dog, also a brand promoter, are made of industrial fibre and painted glow. But those in SILAI talk of them, the three humans and dogs, as if they were breathing and thinking creatures. This is how Maverick Prem, who heads branding at SILAI, describes them: "You will find a man sitting, a very laidback man sitting on a chair and then you will find a woman and she also will hold a dog. And find another man who is running. Each of them has a distinct character. You will find a companion in the man (the one sitting on the bench). You will find grace in the woman and you will find playfulness in the dog. So, each will connect with visitors in its own way."

And when Prem learnt about the widespread consternation over the missing dog, he allayed fears.

"On a morning run, I saw the dog lying, dismantled, on its side. Something had happened; and in a lifeform language, an injury had happened. We took measures, transferring it safely to the factory and right now, the dog is in safe hands, it will be back soon and in the dog's voice, we should say, 'I will be back with a new avatar!'" says Prem. Rough handling by visitors had caused this "injury" to the dog. Prem notes that he and the rest of the people at SILAI are not upset over this.

"At SILAI, we have created this and we wanted people to touch and feel it. That is the idea of a sculpture. In any other art form, people would say, please 'Do not touch'. But we would want to have people touch and feel works of sculpture. And that is the beauty of sculpture."

According to SILAI founder Arun Titan, "a work of sculpture is meant to be touched and felt, and it is in the hands of the people to ensure its safety, through responsible behaviour."

Prem shared pictures of the dog being "treated" and of its journey towards assuming a new avatar.



▼ The Tidel Park junction in Thiruvanniyur. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

New traffic arrangement at Tidel Park junction

A resident who often takes Rajiv Gandhi Salai and West Avenue Road intersection in Thiruvanniyur shared a video with a private Tamil news channel recently that almost went viral. It shows motorists on Rajiv Gandhi Salai heading towards West Avenue Road, blocking the way for motorists going towards the

Adyar region.

The video got the attention of the Chennai Traffic Police and helped effect changes in the flow of traffic on this section of the road.

On Rajiv Gandhi Salai, near Council of Scientific and Industrial Research Road in Taramani, the Greater Chennai Traffic Police have put up barricades with ropes tied

to them upto the median at the Tidel Park junction.

The barricades divide the lanes towards Adyar and the right turn towards Thiruvanniyur.

B. Chandra Bhoominathan, a motorist, says “the board has been put up in the area separating the lanes. The boards notifying the diversion (two lanes) should also be kept near SRP Tools. Recently, I went on the lane towards Thiruvanniyur. Luckily, traffic was light; I could manoeuvre and enter the lane towards Adyar.”

A woman motorcyclist took a U-turn, driving through traffic on the IT Corridor after entering the lane towards Thiruvanniyur.

The other option for two-wheeler riders is to lift the ropes and join the lane either towards Adyar or Thiruvanniyur.

Those driving a car can take a right turn and enter the flyover, but traffic towards Thiruvanniyur will be halted; they should not halt the traffic from Indira Nagar to Taramani, or proceed when traffic from Indira Nagar to Taramani is halted.

Traffic police personnel should also be deployed to stop traffic on the IT Corridor so motorists from CSIR Road can enter the lane towards Thiruvanniyur.

‘Make a new signal at Indira Nagar 2nd Avenue’

KRISHNA KISHORE

I am a resident of Perungudi for more than eight years and travel towards Madhya Kailash every morning. Earlier, the wait at the TIDEL junction was long and dreary. The main problem was the support for a U-Turn from the traffic from Madhya Kailash, and a right turn for the traffic coming from South (Taramani / SRP side), and a right turn for vehicles coming from Thiruvanniyur and entering OMR.

With the U-shaped flyover, two of those have been removed. What remains is one right turn for traffic from South, wanting to take a right towards Thiruvanniyur.

As of last week, traffic police

created a temporary separator near TIDEL junction to force vehicles taking a right to stay in the two right side lanes but that is easier said than done.

For a vehicle emerging from Taramani / CSIR Road to enter the right most lanes is a huge pain to all north-bound traffic.

Newly built U-flyover before VHS may not suit buses and other large vehicles.

Only other possibility is to make the new signal at Indira Nagar 2nd Avenue and widen it to allow buses and other heavy vehicles to take a U-turn there. Until the underground metro construction ends, hope we find more ways to smoothen traffic.

Krishna Kishore is a resident of Perungudi

‘Ensure pedestrians’ safety at junction in Adyar’



At the entrance of IIT-Madras flyover, motorists are forced to slam on the brakes. To avoid crossing Sardar Patel Road, near Gandhi Mandapam and taking a detour to cross outside Anna University, pedestrians cross at the flyover entry lane (towards Besant Nagar and Thiruvanniyur). This not only disrupts traffic, but also puts pedestrians at risk. To avoid this, the pedestrians should be given priority and enough time at Sardar Patel Road and Gandhi Mandapam Road. TEXT AND PHOTO: T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

The third edition of Sprouts IDEA Tank saw school students showcase their imagination, creativity, team skills to present their ideas.

This year’s theme, “Foodpreneurs: Flavours that Sell,” held on September 9, brought together 11 schools, with students turning simple food ideas into interesting business propositions. The afternoon was enriched by the perspectives of restaurateur Manoj Padmanaban (BORN) and professor Pulkit

School students work on food business ideas

Eleven schools take part in the third edition of ‘Sprouts IDEA Tank’ organised by Sprouts Montessori High School

Marwaha (Masters’ Union), who engaged with the young entrepreneurs.

After two hours of enthusiastic pitching, Vruksha Montessori, Sprouts Montessori High School and Akshar Arbol emerged as the

winners. KC High received the award for Innovation, Sprouts’ second team was recognised for Marketing, and DAV Boys Gopalapuram received the award for the Most Cost- Effective Budget, said a release.

In October, Sprouts is partnering with BML Munjal University for “Heroes of Tomorrow”. The initiative will bring together schools from across the city for a multi-layered, SDG-aligned learning experience.

Open House on September 19

Sprouts will conduct its Montessori Open House on September 19, offering parents an opportunity to understand the key areas of learning and development, explore the thoughtfully prepared environment, and see how children learn through choice, movement, practice, exploration and purposeful work.

Sprouts Montessori and High School is at Luz Avenue Road, Mylapore.



LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

S ydenhams Road in Periamet is the “wardrobe” for blue collar workers. On this oft-crowded thoroughfare, from the point where the Greater Chennai Corporation’s headquarters (Ripon Building) begins to the point where the Nehru stadium almost ends, around thirty shops, some found in a cluster and others spaced apart, provide passersby with a peek into this wardrobe.

There is something for almost every front-line worker under the sun. Uniform for security personnel; safety jackets for those working amidst traffic; safety helmets for construction workers; gear tailored for house keeping staff and conservancy workers; shoes, boots, caps and belts associated with the police force; general caps; and laboratory coats. Do not let that “and” hoodwink the reader into thinking this list is exhaustive. It hardly is. Bulk orders placed by corporates government agencies, education institutions and construction companies among others as well as individual purchases sustain this business. And for novelty, orders sometimes fly in from cricket leagues and franchises.

This visual side to Sydenhams Road is familiar for old timers; and it remains its dominant feature. For the superficial eye, little has changed. Can that be said about the eye that has been taking in this “scenery”, day in day out, for years, and even decades? Has anything in the market shifted significantly? As it was established in 1945, United Uniform is probably at an advantage while taking that question. It operates from a shop built into the historic Periamet mosque, established in 1838 by hides and skins traders. After Independence, the mosque would go

‘Safety gear is now the major grosser’

Sydenhams Road, dubbed “the Blue Collar Uniform Hub of Chennai”, supports a section of the unorganised sector that only continues to thrive and grow bigger due to a variety of intrinsic factors



through two reconstruction exercises, and that would give birth to these shops, partly defining the lower reaches of the mosque on one side. Kahifullah Khan, the third generation owner of United Uniform, observes this shop was constructed in 1956. At that time, United Uniform was functioning from what was called ‘Red Building’ in Moore Market with the foun-

der and Kahifullah’s grandfather, Hafizullah Khan at the helm. Kahifullah recalls that the enterprise shifted to its current location in the early 1980s following the much-discussed Moore Market fire, an event that led to the scattering of Moore Market traders dealing in various goods to the nooks and crannies of Madras.

On the question of changes, Ka-

Sydenhams Road and an old unorganised business that is still going strong.



hifullah draws attention to the facade of his shop and those of others in the mosque complex. These shops are noticeably below road level, even coming across as basement shops. With a barely concealed chuckle, he remarks that these shops were once above road level; successive road-laying exercises have got them where they are. In every other aspect, according to him, these small enterprises constituting a segment of the unauthorised sector have been on an upward trajectory.

“There are now more shops in this line of business than ever before,” states Kahifullah, adding the changes have had to do with the major buyers’ mindset, and thankfully, meeting those new expectations is hardly a tough ask.

On the dominant category sold by these shops through the decades, Kahifullah points out that in the 1980s, the focus was largely on police-related products and then a shift happened, greater attention now being accorded to medical items, the coats, then NCC and Scouts uniform and accessories. From the 2010s, safety gear is the major grosser: safety shoes, jackets and helmets easily constitute the highest selling category, he states. Yet another noticeable shift has to do with the choice of material for the making of shoes. Around 15 to 17 years ago, the scales tipped in favour of rexine over leather. And Kahifullah believes this change has been driven primarily by “large-scale manufacturing of rexine in Gujarat and Haryana. Some people even import rexine from Korea and China.”

If one parsed through the resilience of these shops, one factor emerges strongly, a bond that goes beyond a common trade. Kahifullah puts a ballpark number on the shops in this line of business on Sydenhams road, thirty-five, and adds that out of that, around 90 percent of them are run by those

that are part of his extended family. He admits there is competitive pricing, but there is also cooperation. In this climate, sourcing items not in one’s stock from others is possible.

One senses a strong sense of connection and continuity best epitomised by Kahifullah himself. He is essentially a techie, having had a long stint in the IT industry, and he peeled himself from it to keep a family legacy going. He joined this business four years ago following his father Shafifullah’s death in 2022.

The narrative about connections and continuity gains greater ground as more conversations are initiated with these tradespeople. At Khaleel Cap Mart, a misnomer as they sell uniform and accessories in addition to caps, Quraishi, 45, who first came to the shop at age 12, during his school days, remarks that the

name ‘Cap Mart’ is a reminder of those early years. The shop originally specialised in caps, from turbans and Muslim prayer caps or Kufis, to Kashmiri caps. As customer requirements changed. So did the shop’s inventory. One of the shop’s most distinctive products is not necessarily the most conspicuous. Its cotton mosquito nets are made in the traditional way and remain popular among police personnel at various police residential quarters. Depending on the bed type, they cost between ₹500 and ₹1,500. Started by Khaleel Ur Rahman, the shop is now run by Quraishi and his brother Nayeem. Quraishi echoes Kahifullah’s sentiment that this business is on an even keel.

Speaking for the tradespeople in his line of business on Sydenhams Road, Quraishi observes digital buying has left no dent in their business. “Individuals might buy a cap online; for bulk orders, they come to us.”

Old Markets, New Trends

This column features markets that have continued to retain their hold on people’s mind space despite the shifting sands of fads. Through entities that have been around for a long time, it seeks to find out what makes these markets tick

G. SOORIYAMOORTHY
AT WORK

The nuts and bolts of creativity

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

At first glance, it resembles a pile of wires. On closer look, the contours of a face become evident. That is the idea behind G. Sooriyamoorthy's "The Imaginative Metal Wire Portrait of an Artist", one of two sculptures he is preparing for Auras Elemental, an art show where he will stage his experiments with unconventional materials and painstaking techniques spanning 26 years. His second work, "Within the Armour", engaged with a different material and manages a distinct effect: nuts and bolts assembled into the form of a warrior.

The works might differ in appearance, but both reflect Sooriyamoorthy's preference for materials that demand time, precision and physical effort.

"People ask me why I am using

Sculptor G. Sooriyamoorthy promotes the idea of "art made difficult"; and there is a method to this madness. His works will be on display at Lalit Kala Akademi from October 10 to 15

metal wire when it is so time-consuming," he says. His welding shop is in Tambaram, requiring him to travel back and forth from his home in Ayanavaram as he works on the sculptures. "People ask why I put in so much effort when there are easier ways of creating art. For me, the effort is part of the process."

To reach its final form, the wire

portrait consumed three months. The idea came from drawing: Sooriyamoorthy imagined a face made up of multiple lines, with each wire functioning like a line on paper. Instead of lying flat, however, the lines intersect and move through space, gradually forming the figure.

The process involved little machinery. Using cutting pliers, he cut, stretched and tightened the wires before weaving them together. Continuous work for even 30 minutes to an hour could leave his hands hurting. The ponytail was particularly demanding, with individual wires cut to different lengths and shaped by hand. "No large machines were used," he says. A small skull-like structure sits at the centre of the composition, helping hold the interwoven wires together. The construction, which resembles basket-making, gives the sculpture stability despite the thin material. The metal was also treated to achieve an antique finish.

His second sculpture began with a different challenge. Sooriyamoorthy had been looking for an opportunity to experiment with nuts and bolts when he conceived the idea of a warrior. But before he could begin welding, he had to work out the figure itself. He first made a clay model, shaping and carving the anatomy while leaving spaces for the nuts and bolts to fit. The model was then used to make a plaster of Paris mold.

The choice of plaster was practical. Welding generates considerable heat, and Sooriyamoorthy says plaster of Paris absorbs the heat and helps keep the metal cool. Fibre, another material that is generally used for larger sculptures, could pose a fire risk under welding conditions. The nuts and bolts were welded from inside the sculpture. For the warrior's hair, he used 8 mm metal rods, bending and shaping them before welding them into place. The clay model was started around four months ago, while the welding took four days.

"I was able to finish it in a short

An eclectic mix of artists

Auras Elemental, an art exhibition featuring artists at different stages of their creative journeys, will be held from 10 to 15 October 2026 at Lalit Kala Akademi, Thousand Lights. The exhibition, which will be inaugurated on October 9, at 5.30 p.m., brings together emerging artists, first-time exhibitors, passionate learners and experienced professionals, creating a space for diverse artistic practices and perspectives.

The title Auras Elemental reflects the exhibition's focus on the energy and presence surrounding artworks and the raw, instinctive nature of creativity. "Auras" refers to the subtle energies associated with each work, while "Elemental" represents creativity in its pure and unrefined form. The exhibition explores how artistic expression takes shape through instinct, intuition and creative impulse.

Bringing together painters, sculptors, visual artists, designers, art educators, installation artists, digital artists and practitioners from various disciplines, the exhibition presents a range of mediums, approaches and artistic journeys.

span of time because I made sure the clay model was perfect in shape. This allowed me to easily weld the nuts and bolts according to my requirements," he says.

The contrast between the two sculptures also points to Sooriyamoorthy's larger approach to materials. Stone remains his favourite, largely because of the difficulty involved in working with it. Fibre is comparatively easier, he says, while metal and stone require greater time and effort. That difficulty, rather than convenience, appears to be what keeps him experimenting. As he gets the two sculptures ready for Auras Elemental, the material is as much a part of the work as the form it eventually takes.



Social media opening doors to child marriages?

On September 4, 2026, the United Nations General Assembly declared November 27 as the International Day for the Elimination of Child, Early and Forced Marriage. Child rights activists in Chennai weigh in on what it takes, particularly in the online space, to counter the evil of child marriage

LIFFY THOMAS

Last year, the District Child Welfare Committee in Chennai dealt with a case where a 15-year-old girl from Nepal had married a 28-year-old man working in Chennai, the two having met on Instagram. With the help of friends, they got married in Chennai.

A month into the marriage, the girl was traced after she made a call to her sister in Nepal. The girl's family lodged a complaint with the police following which India Child Protection, a civil society organisation working in the area of child protection, intervened to rescue the girl.

Social media and online dating are increasingly exposing vulnerable girls to greater risk of child marriage.

With advancement in digital communication, the *modus operandi* in child marriage is changing, making more children vulnerable," says Bhuwan Ribhu, a child rights activist and founder of Just Rights for Children.

Bhuwan Ribhu says trafficking is a borderless crime, and it requires a borderless response. Online methods of enticement or grooming for marriage, sexual abuse and trafficking have become possible irrespective of distance and geography.

In a study taken by NGO Save the Children, they observed that girls in India faced greater online risk of child marriage and trafficking during the pandemic. The agency continues to work with children and teachers to raise awareness about staying safe online.

According to the National Family

Health Survey (2019-21), the national average in India for child marriage is 23%. The prevalence rate in India for child marriage has fallen by 10 per cent. The Bal Vivah Mukht Bharat campaign launched by the Central Government in November 2024 promises to make India child marriage-free by 2030 and is seeing various state governments running different initiatives.

A dedicated CMPO needed
Natharsha Malim H, state coordinator - Tamil Nadu, India Child Protection, says while Tamil Nadu has been making steady progress in reporting and stopping child marriages, gaps continue to exist.

Tamil Nadu, he says, does not have Child Marriage Prohibition Of-

ficers (CMPOs) that are appointed to prevent marriages, gather evidence, raise awareness and report data. The District Social Welfare Officer (DSWO) is notified as the Child Marriage Prohibition Officer of the concerned district.

"This is an additional role that the DSWO takes up. We have been asking for a dedicated person to be appointed as many other states have done based on a Supreme Court recommendation," says Malim.

For example, in Karnataka, the Department of Women and Child Welfare has included pre-university (PU) college principals as child marriage prohibition officers, whose responsibility is to prevent any girl child studying in their col-

lege from marrying before 18 years.

Dedicated officials tasked with curbing this practice is particularly required in places such as Salem, Dindigul, Namakkal and Cuddalore which has reported maximum cases of child marriages, says Malim. Grama panchayats have to be empowered in these districts to curb child marriage

A rule book for intervention

Malim notes that State Governments have to draw up a Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) for elimination of child marriages.

"The Supreme Court came out with a landmark judgement on child marriages in October 2024, but Tamil Nadu is yet to come out with an SOP," he says.

Panchayats that make an earnest effort to stop child marriage should be rewarded; and the bravery of young girls that resist coercion by family into child marriage should also be acknowledged.

Bhuwan Ribhu cites the example of a study done by India Child Protection in 2025, wherein cases in Assam dropped by 84 percent following a continuous crackdown by law-enforcement authorities.

Although Prohibition of Child Marriage Act, 2006 has been in existence for decades, enforcement leaves a lot to be desired.

"With amendments to the law and judgments by the Supreme Court, we have been able to see much impact on the ground, along with greater awareness," says Ribhu, adding, "awareness needs to be supplemented with the enforcement of policies, accountability of institutions, and the use of technology for monitoring."



ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R KUMAR

A humour-packed evening dedicated to teachers

Eighteen teachers will be presented with Best Teacher Award at the monthly programme of Humour Club today in Mylapore

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

Eighteen teachers will be hogging the limelight at the monthly meeting of Humour Club International - Triplicane chapter. As part of Teachers' Day celebration, the Club will be recreating some "teaching" moments to give audience as well as all the special invitees a memorable evening.

The school bell will ring when the curtains on the stage go up and the 18 Best Teacher Awardees will be shown to the audience. Of the 18 awardees four are members of the humour club. The list includes re-

tired teachers and many currently serving in schools or colleges.

Nonagenarian Vatsala Narayanaswamy, an educationist and director of Sivaswami Kalalaya; and V. Susheela, honorary correspondent of Avvai Home and Orphanage for Girls are the senior awardees. Others include: Sarojini Gowrishankaran, R. Vaidyanathan, Visalakshi Jambunathan, S. Kannan, A. Stella Mary, Gowri Ramesh, P. Gurumoorthy, SV Kalyani, Archana Prasad, Y D. Muthulakshmi; and V. Deepa.

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During the event. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Conference on green chemistry held

A two-day national conference on 'New Trends in Green Chemistry and Sustainable Environment' was held recently at the BSA Crescent Institute of Science and Technology in Vandalur.

Sponsored by the Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF) and the Tamil Nadu State Council for Science and Technology (TNSCST), the event brought top scientists, researchers, and green-tech in-

dustry experts to tackle growing climate and environmental challenges.

The conference focused on creating a cleaner future.

Key topics discussed included eco-friendly chemical manufacturing, reducing hazardous waste, recycling advancements, and sustainable materials designed to support green energy.

Experts noted that while public demand for eco-friendly products is at an all-time high,

scientists must invent newer, safer chemical processes to build a fully circular economy.

Academic scholars presented major research papers detailing new developments. These included eco-friendly food packaging made from biodegradable plants, advanced nanotechnology to clean polluted water systems, leather processing, waste-to-value-added products, and green energy conversion and storage.

Special sweet boxes for Ganesh Chaturthi

Sri Krishna Sweets is bringing special sweets and savouries boxes for Ganesh Chaturthi. Each box includes mysurpa, laddu, sweet kozhukattai, adhirasam, sweet seva, aval mixture, milagu thattai and kara kozhukattai.

With this box, one will receive a Vinayagar clay statue and *prasadam*. The special boxes will be available on September 13 and 14 at all their outlets.

On September 14, hot sweet and kara kozhukattai will be available in Adyar, Alwarpet, Ambattur, Anna Nagar, Ashok Nagar, Bazullah Road, T.Nagar, Chrompet GST Road, Egmore, Guduvanchery, Iyyapanthangal, Jafferkanpet, Madipakkam, Medavakkam, Mylapore, Neelankarai, Porur, Purasaiwakkam, Sembakkam, Tambaram West, Triplicane, Velachery, and Venkatnarayana Road, T Nagar, outlets from 9 a.m. to 1 p.m. till stocks are available.

Velammal Nexus honours teachers



Velammal Nexus felicitated its teachers with service awards and academic excellence awards for their outstanding contributions.

To mark their commitment and achievements, the school

presented prizes worth ₹70 lakh.

Correspondent M. V. M. Velmohan handed over the cheque to the senior in-charges representing all Velammal Nexus schools on behalf of the awardees.

Wildlife photography contest

The Rotary Club of Chennai Crown, in partnership with Madras Photobloggers, is organising 'Yaavarum 2026', a contest for the speech and hearing impaired.

The contest aims to promote wildlife protection through nature conservation and encourage participants to explore, observe, and capture the beauty and importance of the natural world through their own lens.

The contest is open to first-time photographers. Entries will be accepted till

September 30. Each participant may submit up to three photographs, taken with either a mobile phone or a camera. However, AI-generated images will not be permitted.

Winners will be honoured during 'Wildlife Week 2026' in October. The public is requested to share information about the contest with deaf and hard-of-hearing friends, communities, networks, colleges, and institutions for deaf students.

For registration, log on to <https://forms.gle/btUHUV-DYd26UgZpi8>, a press release said.

Hope for people with knee osteoarthritis

Kamakshi Memorial Hospitals has started a "knee-preservation-first approach" to treat advanced osteoarthritis.

Dr. Deepak Kumar K S, Orthopaedic Surgeon, Knee Replacement and Mako Stryker expert, carefully evaluates every patient and explores appropriate treatment options to preserve the natural knee before considering replacement surgery, said a release.

Dr. Deepak has collaborated with Dr. Sathish Kumar Thangamani, a senior assistant professor at Stanley Medical College and consultant at Dr. Kamakshi Memorial Hospitals, to administer allogeneic bone marrow-derived mesenchymal stem cell therapy for select pa-



Dr. Deepak Kumar

tients with knee osteoarthritis.

In a release, Dr Deepak says, "Wherever clinically appropriate, I believe in exploring every possible avenue to preserve the patient's natural knee."

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